

Zire Fire, and Tungsten Zen

Imagine scheduling an urgent meeting, calling up all the executives and getting all the other things on the agenda in place—all from the Palm in your hand. Here are seven PDAs that vie for your attention and promise you that... and more!

Handhelds are much more than souped-up digital diaries; a good Personal Digital Assistant (PDA) can completely change the way you work and play, especially while on the move.

Since the introduction of the first Palm Pilot in 1996, the Palm OS has been the defining factor in the adaptation and evolution of mobile computing. With a Motorola 16 MHz processor and 128 KB of memory, the Palm Pilot 1000 was the first device to feature the Palm OS (v1.0). Since then, the OS has seen numerous revisions and upgrades, continually improving over time.

With a majority market share and millions of devices sold, the Palm OS has become the standard for mobile computing. A wide variety of devices running Palm OS, suitable for different user categories, are now available. The OS also enjoys excellent support from software developers and hardware vendors alike—with loads of options from third-party vendors and independent developers.

Add-on products, such as expansion cards, wireless keyboards, modems, etc., are easily available. Apart from all this, ease of use, great compatibility with Windows-based programs, minimal memory usage and long battery life make devices running on the Palm OS a popular choice world-wide.

Palm devices currently run the v5.x platform. New developments on the OS front include the Palm OS Garnet and Cobalt. Palm OS Garnet is an enhanced version of Palm OS 5, and provides support for a broad range of screen resolutions, dynamic input area, improved network communication and Bluetooth. Cobalt-Palm OS 6 is the next generation of the Palm OS, and has been designed from the ground up, to support new classes of device such as smartphones.

On the hardware front, we've already been seeing a range of Palm OS devices, right from entry-level solutions for first time users, to business PDAs with stretch displays, and smartphones such as the Tungsten W. To help you make an informed decision, we look at some devices running the Palm OS.

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